sufficiency. India was willing to occasionally tread a somewhat lonely path just to be able to stand up to the dominant superpowers.

Since the end of the cold war, close relations with the United States notwithstanding, India remains resistant to being referred to as a US ally, preferring instead the term ‘partner’ or ‘friend.’ Both India and the United States share strategic goals like a stable and secure South Asia and Middle East, countering global terrorism and a common security architecture for the Indo-Pacific region. India now hosts joint military exercises with the United States, and the US is fast becoming one of the top defence suppliers to India. Yet, Indian leaders still view occasional disagreement with the US publicly as critical to India’s autonomy in decision making. Not even partnership with the US in dealing with China’s rise can deter India from continuing to seek leadership status of the smaller non-Western nations.

Although India demands absolute autonomy in bilateral relations with various countries, it is strongly committed to multilateral institutions. For India, global institutions are a mechanism for building solidarity with the developing countries and to present India as a role model for former colonies. During the 1950s and ’60s India championed decolonization across Asia and Africa. Multilateral institutions are the venue for the demand by India’s leaders that the leadership of these primarily Western-led institutions reflect changed global realities. This is the premise behind India’s claim for a permanent seat on the United Nations Security Council and its demand for reformulation of the Bretton Woods financial institutions. India’s often-defiant stance in international institutions like the World Trade Organization (WTO) also stems from its desire for a multipolar world that is no longer dominated by Western powers.

There is a lot in common between both the US and India. Both countries have a somewhat inward-looking, even quasi-isolationist sentiment while at the same time seeking the benefits of globalization. For both, their region – the Americas for one and South Asia for the other – is an area where they